At the start of 2002 President Bush still had his sights on Iraq. He accused the country of being part of **'the axis of evil'**, alongside Iran and North Korea. The USA claimed that Iraq still had WMD and feared that **al-Qaida** might get its hands on them. There was no evidence of any link between al-Qaida and Iraq, but the USA seemed set on invading Iraq. It now had to convince public opinion that invasion would be legitimate. That meant convincing the world that Iraq still had WMD. The US government persuaded the UN to call for the return of weapons inspectors to Iraq and to threaten Iraq with 'serious consequences' if it was obstructive. As the USA built up its forces in the Gulf, Iraq complied. Several months later, the UN team reported that they had found no evidence of WMD.

However, it was now clear that the USA had made up its mind on invasion in order to topple Saddam. The US government still sought UN approval for going to war but Britain was the only one of the other four permanent members of the UN Security Council to support a UN resolution in support of invasion: Russia, China and France were all opposed. In Britain, the Prime Minister, Tony Blair, prepared to take Britain to war in Iraq despite widespread opposition. He claimed that Iraq still had WMD and that some of them could 'be ready within 45 minutes of an order to use them'. Thus, said Blair, Iraq posed a huge threat to peace and stability in the Middle East. Russia, China and France all called for the UN inspectors to have more time to continue their work.

Key terms

**'The axis of evil'**
A phrase used by US President Bush to describe the link he saw between the states that he regarded as enemies.

**Al-Qaida**
From the Arabic word meaning a base (e.g. for training recruits in Afghanistan), it came to refer to an organisation, or a network, of Islamists of whom Osama Bin Laden was the leader. Responsible for the attacks on New York and Washington in 2001.

## The invasion of Iraq, March 2003

The US and British governments did not have the authority of a UN resolution to go to war as they had done in the 1991 war. The forces that invaded Iraq in March 2003 constituted what the US President called 'the coalition of the willing'. The coalition forces were largely made up of American troops, with several thousand British and small contingents from Australia and Poland. It was nothing like the truly multinational force that had driven the Iraqis out of Kuwait in 1991.

As in 1991 the war started with aerial bombardment followed by invasion on land. There was very little Iraqi resistance: many Iraqi troops just melted away. Most Iraqi people remained neutral, not willing to risk their lives to save Saddam's government. There was no great battle for Baghdad, which had already been pounded by American planes, and the capital fell to the Americans after three weeks. British forces took control of Basra, in the south. The Kurds remained in control of their area in the north, as they had done since the 'no-fly zones' were established in 1991. On 1 May 2003 President Bush declared that the war was over. Little did he realise how long the peace would take.

Key dates

Return of UN weapons inspectors to Iraq: 2002

Invasion of Iraq – the Second Gulf War: 2003